

Survey Design Seminar Survey Methods 670

Winter 2026

Week 10: How to Respond to a RFP

March 19, 2026

Outline of Today's Class

- 1. Preparing a response to an RFP**
- 2. Factors in organizing a proposal**
- 3. Budgeting alternatives**
- 4. The Bidders' Conference**

The SWOT Diagram: Deciding Whether to Bid

Strengths All the things that you will deliver well in this project	Weaknesses All the things that you could improve before bidding this project
Opportunities Things that you might be able to take advantage of to improve your chances of winning	Threats Things that might happen to affect your proposed solution negatively

Deciding Whether to Bid

Are resources (time and money) available to prepare a bid?

Who is likely to be the competition?

Will the bid be cost competitive? Can I make a profit?

Create a simple scorecard as in Tables 4.1 and 4.2

Creating a Bid

READ and **REREAD** the RFP carefully, paying attention to the detailed requirements for the bid package

Length

Specified format

Need for supporting documentation

Budgeting requirements

Scoring algorithm for evaluation of the bids

Example of Bid Specifications

IV. REQUIREMENTS FOR SUBMISSION OF PROPOSALS

Proposers should provide a clear, concise response to this RFP with a **maximum length of six pages of single-spaced text with no smaller than 12-point font.**

- A. Introduction & Qualifications.** An introduction of the individual/firm must include (a) a summary of capabilities/qualifications of key personnel involved in this project, (b) special expertise, and (c) experience with similar survey projects. The introduction should convey the consultant's clear understanding of the project requirements. Maximum one page.
- B. Description of Work Plan.** Proposers should provide a response to each task outlined in the SCOPE OF SERVICES in section III. Also include quality assurance efforts for the data collection and analysis tasks, a process for ensuring that no individual respondents will be identified, and a project timeline. The consultant must have sufficient equipment and personnel for back-up and/or emergencies to assure prompt scheduling and completion of services within the schedule. Maximum five pages.
- C. Additional Information as Deemed Appropriate by the Consultant.** Consultants may include any additional information that, in the consultant's opinion, may assist the City in better evaluating the consultant. Maximum one page.
- D. Fees.** Include a matrix which details the full cost of the project broken down by task. This should include hourly rates and a not-to-exceed amount for the total project. Include the estimated average cost per successful telephone call or contact. Provide a list of positions and their estimated hourly billing rates for the first year of the contract. Uses an assumption of 40 successfully completed customer questionnaires per week are collected. Provide detail and assumptions to estimate the average cost per questionnaire completed by a customer.

Example of Bid Specifications

V. RFP PROPSAL EVALUATION CRITERIA

The five criteria categories listed below will be used to rate each proposal. The weighted percentage rating for each criterion is indicated below.

- A. Conformance to the specified RFP format, as outlined in section III. 5%
- B. Organization, presentation and content of proposal. 5%



- C. Proposed methods and overall plan to accomplish the scope of services in a timely and competent manner. 60%
- D. Experience, professional and technical skills in the field of survey research. 15%
- E. Competitive fees and rates. 15%

Example of Bid Specifications

III. SCOPE OF SERVICES

The consultant will report to staff in the Development Services Department. We expect that the consultant will provide services to the City promptly after being hired and that the effort will last approximately one year. Upon satisfactory performance, the contract will have an option to extend the contractual relationship annually for a total of five years.

The selected consultant will be required to perform the following tasks:

- A. Identify key drivers of customer satisfaction.** Conduct at least three qualitative focus groups of 8 to 10 customers annually. Conduct at least 6 executive interviews annually with customers from the development community. After the initial identification of key drivers of customer satisfaction, the focus groups and executive interviews will be conducted annually to periodically assess the current validity of key drivers of customer satisfaction.
- B. Develop, pre-test and finalize questionnaires.** Work with City staff to develop new telephone surveys. After consultation and input, final draft questionnaires will be developed for the surveys which will also serve as the pre-test questionnaire. An alternative to telephone surveys such as web-based surveying is acceptable if it can be validated that the alternative to telephone surveying will result in statistically valid non-self-selecting survey results. A survey program utilizing written questionnaires survey instrument is not acceptable.
- C. Update, Pre-test and Finalize Questionnaires.** The consultant will work together with City staff to make modifications to the existing survey administered by telephone. After consultation and input, final draft questionnaires will be developed for the surveys which will also serve as the pre-test questionnaire.
- D. Develop Sampling Plan.** The consultant will develop a sampling plan. A mechanism will be

Example of Bid Specifications

in place by the consultant to evaluate the sample population (at any time during data collection) to ensure that the participant base is representative of the larger Development Services customer population under investigation. The number of interviews conducted with participants should reflect sample sizes with enough power to detect significance at a 95% confidence level.

E. Training. The consultant will conduct an interviewer training session so that each survey interviewer is familiar with the Department's surveys. Information in any developed proposal should include the length of training, methodology and content of the session.

F. Conduct Survey/Data Collection. Directly conduct telephone surveys or subcontract services for the completion of telephone questionnaires. A plan will be developed and successfully implemented to ensure that the information collected from customers is accurate. Survey questioning will be conducted on a weekly basis. Development Services will provide the customer contact information to the consultant.

A toll free number should be made available to allow customers being surveyed the option to call in at the customers' convenience to complete the survey. This is most useful in cases where a customer is not at home and a message can be left on the customer's telephone answering machine.

G. Analyze Data. Include in the proposal a description of the methodology used for analyzing the data and information on the type of software used. It is expected that the consultant will compare most recent survey results with previously collected results.

H. Provide Results. Consultant will provide complete written results of key drivers of customer satisfaction within 30 calendar days of completion of the last focus group or executive developer interview initiating the survey. A report of customer satisfaction questionnaire responses will be required on at least a monthly basis. The results of the monthly reports will be required within 14 calendar days of the last day of the month. If sampling sizes are not adequate to provide statistically valid results for any of the surveys on a monthly basis, then monthly reports will still be required and a separate quarterly report with statistically valid results will be reported.

The Structure of a NSF Proposal (15 pages max)

This is a request for a grant award and will undergo peer review in 2 stages

Issues of equity as well as scientific excellence are relevant

Funds are limited (generally or for a specific announcement). While there could be more than one funded proposal (grant), excellent evaluations are required. In theory, there could be no awards if there are no excellent proposals.

Regular reviews are conducted periodically (2, 3, or 4 times a year), but announcement may be one-time or less frequent periods

The Structure of a NSF Proposal (15 pages max)

- 1. Title**
- 2. Abstract (Summary) (~250 words 0.5 page)**
- 3. Hypothesis statement or goals – should be clear and well written (1-3 sentences each)**
- 4. Specific Aims (typically 2-4 specific aims; 1-2 pages)**
- 5. Background & Significance (2-3 pages) Helps the reviewer to understand the problem being addressed. Avoids jargon that only experts will appreciate.**
- 6. Preliminary Data (2-3 pages)**
- 7. Research Design and Methods (6-8 pages approximately $\frac{1}{2}$ the total proposal length)**
Describe the experimental design and procedures in detail and give a rationale for their use.
- 8. Conclusion /Summary (0.5 page) A conclusion summarizing why this research needs to be done, how it will advance the field, why you're excited to do this**
- 9. References (unlimited pages)**

All figures, diagrams, charts, photos (etc.) are included as part of the page limits.

Examples of Guidelines for Preparing NSF Proposals

<https://orsp.umich.edu/proposal-writers-guide-overview>

https://www.colorado.edu/ocg/sites/default/files/attached-files/nsf_tipsheet2016_0.pdf

The Main Elements of the Budget Narrative

Important concepts:

Overall effort vs. work on tasks

Direct vs. indirect costs

Main budgetary elements

Research staff

Salaries and wages

Technical staff

Clerical and administrative staff

Fringe benefits

Consumable supplies and materials

Equipment

Consultants and subcontracts

Sample UM Budget template: <https://orsp.umich.edu/sample-budget-table>

What Procurement People Are Looking For

The type of procurement to use: Sole Source, Competitive

They often make a recommendation to someone else but don't have final say over selection – who will that be?

What Procurement People Are Looking For

DISLIKES

Waffling, boasting, flattery
Missing information, incomplete responses
Hidden, missing pricing
Hard to find information, multiple cross-references
Unsubstantiated claims w/out evidence of experience
Jargon
No attempt to clarify questions, incorrect assumptions
Asking for information already in the RFP
Requests for deadline extensions
Non-compliant bids, suggestion the wrong question asked

LIKES

Logical, well-constructed documents
Evidence of capacity, capability, experience
Compliant solutions meeting specification
Quantifiable value in the compliant solution
Added value
Owned solutions, commitment to contract management
Innovation and fresh thinking in proposed solution
Respect for the process
Clearly labeled submissions
Evidence the bidder wants the work

The Structure of a Commercial Bid

Organize the bid preparation just like a project

Set a timetable, leaving room for editing and production

Assign responsibilities to individuals: Project GANTT chart

Have a preliminary meeting to discuss approaches and designs: what don't we know?

Discuss bidder questions

Identify the customer's key challenges and requirements

Reduce costs?

Improve data quality?

Improve customer satisfaction? Decrease churn?

Dissatisfaction with the current service supplier?

Next Steps

Create a story board for the proposal narrative

Your business's strengths and advantages

Benefits of working with your unit

Things that distinguish you from other likely bidders

Identification of a theme that differentiates you from others

See examples on pp. 93-94:

Innovation, Reliability, Quality, Low cost, etc.

Think in advance about the executive summary, although the final version may not be complete until after the rest of the text is ready

How to Price the Proposal

Are there options or alternative design possibilities?

Think about a budget with options, not a single number

This could be expressed in terms of:

Fixed vs variable costs

Consideration of precision or data quality concerns

What are your own business requirements in terms of payment schedule? Up front money?

How the budget affects the proposal: Bottom up approach that totals estimated costs vs. satisficing within a fixed available amount

How much weight does the budget get in evaluation?

Formulate a Project Management Plan

A project requires TWO PLANS: a calendar for effort as well as expenditures. This relates to cash flow and expected payment.

Think about a project that requires 1,000 completed interviews of 1 hour length. How should this be budgeted?

If page limits allow, think about a GANTT chart that shows work flow, critical delivery dates, and expected payment dates

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gantt_chart

Formulate a Project Management Plan

Do you budget at the **hourly rate⁺** or at the **loaded or fully burdened rate?**

Could include fringe benefits and/or profit margin (depends on IDC?)

Total Cost = Direct Cost + Indirect Cost

The NSF Budget template provides a guide to necessary items but does not have to replicated exactly

The Bidder's (Contractors' / Vendors') Conference

The purpose of the bidder conference is to make sure that the prospective sellers have the same information from the project which they can use to prepare their proposals.

This information may include the overview of the organization, qualification of the bidder, the scope of the project, minimum requirements and the deliverables.

Is it optional or mandatory?

What do I need to know that was not covered in the RFP?

The Bidder's (Contractors' / Vendors') Conference

Typical conduct of a Bidders' Conference

- **Introduction and opening remarks**
- **Presentation on the procurement aspects of the proposal**
- **Questions and answers on the procurement aspects**
- **Presentation on the technical aspects of the proposal**
- **Question and answers on the technical aspects**
- **Closing remarks**

The strategy of Q & A